Ireland: energy security, economic opportunity and partnership priorities

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AI-generated from the data and checked against it; paper baseline as of 12 October 2026.

Summary

- Ireland is most exposed in upstream nuclear, downstream coal and upstream oil, where its Energy Security is higher than only 11%, 15% and 22% of the other economies scored. Its oil production falls short of consumption.[1]
- Its strongest openings are in downstream geothermal, upstream green hydrogen and downstream green hydrogen, where its Economic Opportunity is higher than 94%, 92% and 90% of the other economies scored. Each is lifted by cost competitiveness, growth in use or both.[1]
- On the paper's weighting, the Strategic Index puts upstream nuclear 1st among Ireland's own sectors, almost tied with upstream wind; policy activity places it in the middle group.[1]
- The Partnership Strength Index rates the United States highest for Ireland, as a reliable supplier; it is also Ireland's 2nd trade partner, while China, its 7th, ranks 52nd on Partnership Strength.[1,2]

1. Energy security risks and why

15 of Ireland's 30 placed sectors, those where both scores can be compared with other economies, sit in the two low-energy-security corners. Compared with other economies in each sector, its Energy Security is lowest in upstream nuclear, downstream coal, upstream oil and midstream batteries. It is higher than only 11%, 15%, 22% and 25% of the other 174, 98, 96 and 53 economies scored, with scores of 0.16, 0.39, 0.37 and 0.31. Of these, upstream nuclear sits in the Upgrade corner and the others in the Secure corner. The paper's framework associates the Upgrade corner with building domestic capability and the Secure corner with securing supply through partners.[1]

The data mark upstream nuclear, upstream wind and downstream solar as its high-priority sectors. In upstream nuclear, trade pulls the score down: Ireland's share of world exports of these goods was 0.0% in 2023. In upstream wind, trade also pulls the score down: on its trade deficit in these goods, <0.1% of GDP in 2023, it scores higher than only 6% of the other economies.[1,3]

In upstream oil, import needs and reserves pull the score down. Production minus consumption was -0.303 EJ in 2025, with production from the U.S. Energy Information Administration's international statistics, as the Energy Institute does not report it separately. No oil reserves are recorded, which the index counts as zero. In downstream coal, energy access pulls it down: over the years to 2025, consumption per person changed by -69.2%, to 2.24 GJ per person. In midstream batteries, investment pulls it down: no investment or manufacturing capacity is recorded, which the index counts as zero.[4,5]

For context, its largest suppliers in upstream oil in 2024 were the United States (24.8% of imports, which totalled USD 5.54 bn) and the Netherlands (23.6%). In upstream wind, Norway supplied 99.2% of its imports.[2]

2. Economic opportunities and why

24 of the 30 placed sectors sit in the two high-opportunity corners, where Economic Opportunity is above the sector's middle economy. Compared with other economies in each sector, its Economic Opportunity is highest in downstream geothermal, upstream green hydrogen, downstream green hydrogen and midstream green hydrogen. It is higher than 94%, 92%, 90% and 90% of the other 102, 83, 157 and 39 economies scored. Of these, downstream geothermal sits in the Upgrade corner and the others in the Grow corner.[1]

Cost competitiveness pushes the score up in downstream geothermal and upstream green hydrogen: on input costs of labour and capital, Ireland scores higher than 88% and 95% of the other economies respectively. In downstream green hydrogen, consumption pushes it up: on expected growth in use per person it scores higher than 81% of the other economies, and on use per person today higher than 83%.[1]

Among the high-priority sectors, downstream solar has Economic Opportunity higher than 88% of the other 147 economies scored. Cost competitiveness pushes it up: on input costs it scores higher than 98% of the other economies. Its Economic Opportunity in upstream nuclear and upstream wind is higher than 61% and 67% of the other economies scored.[1]

3. Sectoral priorities and the existing policy posture

The Strategic Index ranks a country's own sectors by combining opportunity, security need, policy activity, the supply-chain stage and the technology's low-emission value. On the paper's weighting, it puts upstream nuclear 1st, upstream wind 2nd, upstream solar 3rd, midstream batteries 4th and downstream solar 5th among Ireland's own sectors. The leader, upstream nuclear, scores 0.65, only 0.007 ahead of the next, so they are almost tied. Further down, upstream solar, midstream batteries and downstream solar are also almost tied, with gaps of 0.002 and 0.003. In upstream nuclear, security need adds 0.251 to the score, against 0.155 for opportunity.[1]

The allied pick, the leading upstream or midstream sector after a screen for a resource base, is midstream batteries (0.64), 0.024 ahead of midstream solar. The screen leaves out upstream nuclear, upstream wind and upstream solar because no resource base is recorded for them.[6]

Comparing priority, the index without its policy term, with policy activity, midstream batteries and midstream solar combine top priority with the most policy. No top-priority sector falls in the group with the least policy, while downstream green hydrogen combines bottom priority with the most policy. The sectors with bottom priority and the least policy are upstream oil, midstream gas, midstream oil, upstream coal, downstream coal, midstream coal and downstream oil. Its leading Strategic Index sector, upstream nuclear, has 0 International Energy Agency Policies and Measures records naming the technology. Ireland carries the Climate Action Tracker rating Insufficient (November 2024) and has 183 Policies and Measures records, 88 of which name a technology.[1,7,8]

4. Partnership priorities and why

The Partnership Strength Index rates partners as suppliers (Friendshore), as markets for exports (Partnership Opportunity) and, for middle- and lower-income partners, by Development Potential. From Ireland's viewpoint it ranks the United States 1st, the United Kingdom 2nd, the Netherlands 3rd, Germany 4th and Italy 5th of 189 partners. The United States, the Netherlands and Germany stand out most as a reliable supplier; the United States' best sectors as a supplier are upstream nuclear, midstream wind, upstream gas, midstream batteries and upstream wind. The United Kingdom and Italy stand out most as an export market.[1]

These priorities match today's ties. The United Kingdom is Ireland's 1st trade partner on average across its energy-goods baskets, the United States its 2nd, Germany its 3rd, the Netherlands its 4th and Italy its 9th. Each is a priority partner with strong ties today and votes in the same bloc as Ireland at the UN. Norway, its 5th trade partner, ranks 22nd on Partnership Strength. By contrast, China is its 7th trade partner but ranks 52nd, and they vote in opposite blocs at the UN.[1,2,9]

As a partner to the coalition, Ireland ranks 15th of 192 economies, on Partnership Strength averaged over the core members' viewpoints. In the allied network design, which spreads production of each upstream and midstream sector across coalition members, its largest designed share is 0.7% of midstream green hydrogen.[1,6]

5. Data notes and caveats

Country Insights shows these values as of 12 October 2026. Scores compare Ireland with other economies in the same sector; they are not measures of risk or profit in absolute terms. All index values are the paper's baseline as of 12 October 2026; Strategic Insights recomputes them under other weightings. Strategic Index scores within 0.01 of each other are almost tied: small changes in the data or the weights can swap their order. Some figures behind these scores are filled in where the source has no value: with zero where a source lists every holder, otherwise with the world average. Many allied picks are close calls: in the paper, 37% of them are within 0.01 of the runner-up. In the allied network design the European Union is one producer; Ireland's shares are derived from its weight within the EU. The Climate Action Tracker rates the EU as a whole; Ireland carries the EU's rating. Ireland's counts leave out the EU's own 438 International Energy Agency policy records. Trade figures count trade with other EU members.

Sources

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